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Newsmakers

MOHAN BHAGWAT 75
Sarsanghchalak, RSS

The Quiet Authority

From nudging the BJP into a political course-correction to being a moral evangelist at large, 2025 saw Bhagwat shape outcomes without overtly occupying centre stage

By **ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**



IN **Nagpur's Reshimbagh ground, under the mellow October sun,** Mohan Bhagwat walked to the dais with his familiar unhurried stride. Saffron flags fluttered, thousands of uniformed cadre stood in formation, and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) anthem filled the air. The ritual was a familiar one, but this particular enactment of it marked a special milestone. The RSS, born in 1925, was ringing in a full centenary. If the weight of the moment needed a figure with a natural, unforced air of authority to embody it and project it outward—without shouting—the sarsanghchalak, himself now 75, answered to that description perfectly.

It's not just tradition that vests him with that authority. The year 2025 demonstrated its currency value in the political sphere, sealing beyond all doubt signs of the street power visible in 2024. Across five elections, it was made abundantly clear that when the RSS recuses itself from electoral groundwork, its political progeny suffers. On the other hand, when the vast infantry of the Sangh fans out to till the field ahead of voting, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) reaps the harvest. Juxtapose the scare the BJP received in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, especially in Uttar Pradesh, against its subsequent landslide wins in Haryana, Maharashtra, Delhi and Bihar, and the axiom meets its QED.

That's why Bhagwat is often described as the most influential Indian after Prime Minister Narendra Modi. That's also why, when he speaks, the political class listens. To his credit, he wears this power lightly and with sobriety, not venturing overmuch into everyday policymaking, nor creating rancour, but speaking just enough to perform his essential role: being the ideological compass of the larger

In a year when the RSS turned 100 and he 75, Bhagwat embodied authority rooted in continuity